

The Transcend JetFlash V30 turned out to be the proverbial tortoise, as did the Corsair Voyager 1GB, while the Toshiba 1 GB neatly separated these two from the hares.

Conclusion

A 1 GB drive is only recommended when you absolutely cannot afford to spend any more. We say this because two and four GB drives are faster—larger density flash modules tend to have better data transfer rates—and offer more value for money. If you are specifically shopping for a 1 GB drive our *Digit Best Buy Gold* winner—the Moser Baer 1 GB—is your best bet.

SLIGHTLY OVERWEIGHT—2 GB

One glance at Umax's Apus Zoom had us humming Roxette's *She's got the look*—a jet black drive with two silver-chrome strips on each side, it's pretty, but didn't feel sturdy enough. The SanDisk Cruiser Titanium was another attraction—solid metal body (as the name suggests) and a dark gun-grey colour. The regular Cruiser drive is identical looking except that the material used is high quality plastic rather than metal. Corsair's rugged Voyager series made another appearance with its 2 GB avatar. Buffalo's Turbo USB 2.0 is a cool looking transparent drive—though there's nothing in terms of moving parts to make any sense of the transparency. It's a pity that Buffalo didn't add an activity LED.

We also had a bulky Kingston DataTraveler Reader which cunningly incorporates a memory card reader into the regular pen drive. This is a good option if you need both a USB drive and a memory card reader. It's not built very well though. Transcend's JetFlash V10, on the other hand, is built solidly, but is uninspiring to look at.

Buffalo's 2GB offering uses a technology called Turbo USB, which requires a small download from their Web site. This software once installed on the PC claims to help speed up

transfers and seems to be some sort of buffering software. Another software called Buffalo Secure Lock Ware which is a security package can be downloaded and installed. We couldn't see the reason why such software couldn't be bundled on a disk, or in the drive itself. They are still "bundled software" if you think about it, and all Buffalo's drives feature them.

Performance

Corsair's Voyager 2 GB did a complete turnaround of our initial impressions with the 1 GB model—it was fast, so much so that it nearly overtook the speed demon that was the Transcend JetFlash V10. Both the SanDisk drives just tagged behind the leaders and strangely did very well with large write operations involving multiple small files—better than the two overall leaders. Funnily the scenario changes when we look at the small 100 MB file transfer tests, where the Cruzers lag behind, although by a small margin.

The Moser Baer 2 GB was a ubiquitous performer—fast, but amid faster drives, unlike its smaller sibling. The attractive Kingston DataTraveler 2 GB was abysmally slow.

Conclusion

Whether you're looking at speed or something tough enough to withstand a few drops from your pocket look no further than our *Digit Best Buy Gold* winner—Corsair's Voyager 2 GB. It even comes with an attractive transparent USB extension cable so you won't have to get dusty fiddling around the rear of your cabinet if you don't have front USB ports. Best of all, it costs a measly Rs 900!

The SanDisk U3-based brothers, the Cruzer Titanium and the Cruzer, also make very good buys for someone wanting a fast drive. These make sense, because if you're planning on transferring close to 2 GB of data regularly, it's pointless to choose something slow. Transcend's JetFlash V10 2 GB (Rs 800) was also fast, similar to the V10 1 GB in the previous group.

Transcend clearly uses much faster Flash chips in their V10 series as compared to their V30 series—which seem the slowest of the Transcend drives. In fact the Transcend JetFlash V30 is such a slowcoach that only one drive in this category was slower—this dubious honour belonging to the Umax Apus Zoom 2 GB—unless you plan quick naps between large write operations you'll stay well away. Toshiba's U3 offering was also well below the standard of what is considered fast—and if you want a U3 based drive we can't recommend this after the brilliant SanDisk Cruzers.

CERTIFIED FAT-4 GB

The 4 GB segment is where all the fun starts, mainly because just six months ago these drives were double the price they are today. There is also a lot more data you can carry around—photos, movies, and music. The math is simple too—double the price of a 2 GB gives you double the storage space.



Corsair Voyager 2 GB
The most rugged data logger

The Blue Whale—Corsair Voyager 16 GB

The only really *large* drive we were able to get our hands on was a Corsair Voyager featuring a massive 16 GB. Although their catalogue shows that the 32 GB variant is a market reality, availability is a different story. This drive features the same ruggedness that the Voyager series are famous for, and shares even the same colour. In fact, if not for the tiny 16 GB imprint on the translucent rubber that covers the activity LED, you wouldn't be able to tell it apart from their other versions—it looks just like the 2 GB version shown above.

It was a pity to see such a large drive thrashed in our random write tests, though. Although this particular test brings most drives to their knees, we were hoping for a different result here. Alas, with assorted write speeds of 1 and 2.35 MBps the Voyager 16 GB isn't as fast as its target audience would want it to be. If you want a 16 GB drive, you're probably a movie buff or an enthusiast, looking to transport dual-layer ISOs or rather large games on this drive, which might end up being a painful wait.

Overall, this drive is a benchmark for the size we'd like to see become *de facto* next year. But there's not much going for the Voyager besides its size and of course its price—Rs 6,990. Imagine lugging your MP3s to office and back. Got a bigger music collection than that? Wait for the 32 GB version, and pray that it's much faster.

One drive stands out in this category—the Sandisk Extreme Ducati Edition. The D word causes the motorcycling enthusiasts amongst us to get weak-kneed and dry mouthed with anticipation. This drive features a solid metal upper body (painted Ducati-red) with a quality plastic bottom. The USB interface safely tucks away and the LED indicator is made to look like the tail-light of a super bike. The drive also features SanDisk's famous *Extreme* Flash memory, which obviously made us want to test it first.

Also in this category were Kingston's Data Traveler Mini and Data Traveler Mini Fun are really tiny drives. The Traveler Mini has a very neat retracting system which completely tucks away the USB interface beneath its tiny exterior. The Mini Fun is designed to look funky—and is a bright red. Note that besides their diminutive size these are full fledged USB drives—Kingston hasn't cut corners on functionality.

Toshiba's TransMemory 4 GB has one of the curviest forms—straight body curved inwards at either end. A very attractive dark grey plastic body does justice to a beautiful footprint.

Tech-Com's 4 GB offering came with DiskPro on the firmware. This software appears as a discrete floppy drive. Double clicking this drive will bring up a screen that will query for a password to protect access to the drive. You can also set a hint question. What's best about this is that the drive cannot be formatted without providing the password (a contrast to the poor security suite on the

Corsair Voyager drives). Tech-Com also provided good accessories—a long USB extension cable and a neat lanyard.

Performance

Ducatis are known for their performance, aren't they? True to its heritage, the SanDisk Extreme Ducati Edition blows everything in this comparison to smithereens—it was puzzlingly slow in the 100 MB assorted write, though still faster than the other drives and that was it—no more complaints! With a random write speed of 13.34 MBps for 4 GB of assorted files and an equally amazing 18.06 MBps for sequential write, this drive is two and sometimes three times faster than most other drives.

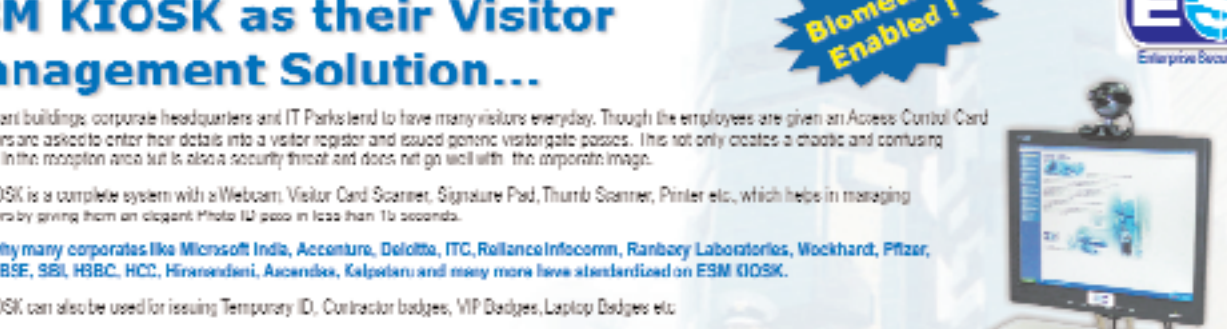
The only other two contenders barely close enough to choke on the exhaust fumes of the SanDisk Extreme Ducati Edition, were the JetFlash V10 4 GB from Transcend and the Corsair Voyager 4 GB. The stragglers consisted of the Imation Nano 4 GB, the Tech-Com 4 GB, Toshiba TransMemory 4 GB, and the Kingston Data Traveler 100.

Conclusion

If our hearts ruled our heads we'd award the SanDisk Extreme Ducati Edition with gold and forget about this category. However its not the wisest choice and not everyone will want to spend three times more for double the speed. That established, *Digit's Best Buy Gold* goes to



Transcend JetFlash V10 4 GB
When performance and price collide



**Many leading corporates trust
ESM KIOSK as their Visitor
Management Solution...**

Multitenant buildings, corporate headquarters and IT Parks tend to have many visitors everyday. Though the employees are given an Access Control Card the visitors are asked to enter their details into a visitor register and issued generic visitorgate passes. This not only creates a chaotic and confusing situation in the reception area but is also a security threat and does not go well with the corporate image.

ESM KIOSK is a complete system with a Webcam, Visitor Card Scanner, Signature Pad, Thumb Scanner, Printer etc., which helps in managing the visitors by giving them an elegant Photo ID pass in less than 10 seconds.

That's why many corporates like Microsoft India, Accenture, Deloitte, ITC, Reliance Infocomm, Ranbaxy Laboratories, Wockhard, Pfizer, Pilella, BSE, SBI, HBBC, HCC, Hiranandani, Ascendas, Kalpataru and many more have standardized on ESM KIOSK.

ESM KIOSK can also be used for issuing Temporary ID, Contractor badges, VIP Badges, Laptop Badges etc

Soft-AID Computers (P) Ltd.
3rd floor, 4th Dimension, 135, Broadway, Pune - 411004 INDIA
Tel: +91 20 25452005 (3 lines)
Fax: +91 20 25460063
E-mail: sales@ilifeville.com
Mumbai (Sachin - 9324312103) Delhi (Ansh - 9911930420) Bangalore (Kumar - 9144278964)
Hyderabad (Mallesh - 9447277000) Pune (Sunil - 9900081909)

ESM Kiosk
An important gadget for every modern facility

www.visitor-management.net